The Congress steadfastly opposed the British war effort and most Congress leaders spent the war years in prison or in exile.

The 1942 Quit India resolution of the Congress passed in Bombay championed the cause of a world federation, pointing out that

> … the future peace, security and ordered progress of the world demand a world federation of free nations, as on no other basis can the problems of the modern world be solved. Such a world federation will ensure the freedom of its constituent nations, the prevention of exploitation by one nation over another, the protection of national minorities, the advancement of all backward areas and peoples and the pooling of the world's resources for the common good of all.[79]

Congress's non-cooperation with the British during the war years created space for the Muslim League's demand for partition of India; but it did have the effect of forcing the British to reconsider their belief in holding on to India indefinitely. By the time the war ended, Indian independence became inevitable. In 1945, though not yet an independent country, India was represented at the San Francisco Conference and signed the United Nations charter.

Thus, over the years, the political party that led India to independence had laid down the guiding principles for the conduct of India's international affairs. These included expression of a desire to cooperate with other countries, support for anti-imperial and anti-colonial struggles and championing peace around the world. The Congress also committed India to abiding by the Charter of the United Nations, promoting Asian solidarity and seeking the recognition of India as a non-militarist great power. Many of India's post-Independence initiatives, including non-alignment, the Panchasheel (five principles of coexistence) and the opposition to multilateral military alliances can be traced to the deliberations of the Indian National Congress during the independence struggle.